businesspeople are concerned about, and how politicians try to make a name for themselves. And priorities are often shaped by our understanding of history.

While so-called realists dismiss historical narratives as propaganda ploys deployed to advance state interests, in fact it is these narratives that define state interests in the first place. As we saw in our discussion of Clausewitz's theory of war, there is no rational way to define ultimate goals. The state interests of Russia, Israel, Myanmar or any other country can never be deduced from some mathematical or physical equation; they are always the supposed moral of a historical narrative.

It is therefore hardly surprising that politicians all over the world spend a lot of time and effort recounting historical narratives. The above-mentioned example of Vladimir Putin is hardly exceptional in this respect. In 2005 the UN secretary-general, Kofi Annan, had his first meeting with General Than Shwe, then the dictator of Myanmar. Annan was advised to speak first, so as to prevent the general from monopolising the conversation, which was meant to last only twenty minutes. But Than Shwe struck first and held forth for nearly an hour on the history of Myanmar, hardly giving the UN secretary-general any chance to speak.[2] In May 2011 the Israeli prime minister Benjamin Netanyahu did something similar in the White House, when he met the US president, Barack Obama. After Obama's brief introductory remarks, Netanyahu subjected the president to a long lecture about the history of Israel and the Jewish people, treating Obama as if he were his student.[3] Cynics might argue that Than Shwe and Netanyahu hardly cared about the facts of history and were deliberately distorting them in order to achieve some political goal. But these political goals were themselves the product of deeply held convictions about history.

In my own conversations on AI with politicians, as well as tech entrepreneurs, history has often emerged as a central theme. Some of my interlocutors painted a rosy picture of history and were accordingly enthusiastic about AI. They argued that more information has always meant more knowledge and that by increasing our knowledge, every previous information revolution has greatly benefited humankind. Didn't the print revolution lead to the scientific revolution? Didn't newspapers and radio lead to the rise of modern democracy? The same, they said, would happen with AI. Others had a dimmer perspective, but nevertheless expressed hope